

the national landscape, this has also turned the spotlight on Bimal Patel, the Ahmedabad-based architect responsible for designing the latter two projects.

Patel's association with high profile mega-projects closely tied to the PM's political prestige (his earlier commissions include the Sabarmati riverfront redevelopment in Ahmedabad, the chief minister's secretariat in Gandhinagar and the interior design of the new BJP headquarters in Delhi) have inevitably brought him professional fame—with a side-order of controversy. The Central Vista makeover in particular has attracted considerable fury and disapprobation from a vocal section of architecture, heritage and urban planning professionals—and many ordinary Dilliwalas besides. The project first came to public notice in September 2019, thanks to a leak of the video proposals submitted for the project by a select clutch of architectural firms with the wherewithal to furnish the required 'earnest money' of Rs 50 lakh. The announcement, shortly thereafter, that Patel had been awarded the contract was met with a quantum of relief that some of the other more outrageous proposals (read Hafeez Contractor) had been rejected, followed by growing disquiet, as the scale and ambition of the winner's design sank in. The HCP video proposed at least 10 new eight-storied office blocks bracketing Rajpath and the demolition of nearly all existing buildings below Raisina hill. A new triangular parliament building and residences for the PM and vice-president were also inserted into the landscape along with a new PMO, while the historic central secretariat and parliament buildings were to be repurposed as museums.

While the government and its customary talking heads did little to address the mounting outrage (at least in heritage circles) at the perceived threat to one of the country's most iconic public spaces, Patel

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